

Carne Asada Picada

Lime-cumin marinade · diced shoulder clod · griddle chop-and-sear · freezer bags

PORTION	MARINATE	DICE	FREEZER
450 g bags	4 hr–overnight	$\frac{3}{8}$ – $\frac{1}{2}$ " cross-grain	3+ months

KEY TARGETS

it's beef — sear hard, pull at medium, don't cook it through

Griddle surface (IR)	450–500°F	Internal pull temp	130–140°F
Char coverage	15–20%	Final texture	crusty edge, tender
Dice	$\frac{3}{8}$ – $\frac{1}{2}$ ", cross-grain	Marinade	coats, not watery

MARINADE FORMULA

% of beef wt · per 450 g bag · per full ~24 lb (11 kg) clod

Beef shoulder clod diced $\frac{3}{8}$ – $\frac{1}{2}$ ", across grain	100%	450 g	11 kg
Lime juice fresh, pure — no orange	9%	40 g	990 g
Neutral or olive oil	6%	27 g	660 g
White onion rough chunks, to blend	4%	18 g	440 g
Garlic peeled cloves, to blend	3.5%	16 g	385 g
Maggi seasoning Jugo — umami backbone	2%	9 g	220 g
Cumin, ground the lead	0.8%	3.6 g	88 g
Mexican oregano	0.4%	1.8 g	44 g
Black pepper	0.4%	1.8 g	44 g
Salt Diamond Crystal, by wt	1.3%	6 g	143 g

Same freezer engine as the al pastor: the acid is paused while frozen, so the bags keep for **months** — the only danger window is the thaw. **Thaw to barely-pliable (still cold), then griddle ripping hot;** never let diced beef lounge fully thawed in the lime or it goes mealy. **Dice across the grain and pull at medium** — this is beef, not the pollo, so don't cook it through. **No heat lives in the bag by design** — build it with salsas and chiles at the table. **Salt by weight is brand-independent:** the 6 g is Diamond Crystal; Morton = 60% (3.6 g), table = 50% (3 g).

Make Ahead & Cook

PREP & FREEZE

build the bags ahead — the marinade works through the freeze + thaw

- 1 **Dice:** trim the shoulder clod and cut $\frac{3}{8}$ – $\frac{1}{2}$ " (1–1.5 cm) **cubes across the grain** — uniform for even searing, cross-grain for tenderness.
- 2 **Blend:** everything except the beef into a blender — blend smooth. No grating; it scales clean and coats evenly for bulk.
- 3 **Combine:** toss the diced beef in the blended marinade until every piece is coated — a large tub / bus tub for a full clod.
- 4 **Portion + freeze:** into quart bags (450 g each), press flat, remove air, label with the date, freeze.

COOK FROM FROZEN

ripping-hot griddle — sear, don't steam

- 5 **Thaw:** fridge overnight, or a cold-water bath, to **barely-pliable and still cold** — don't let it fully soften in the acid.
- 6 **Griddle:** cast iron / flat-top ripping hot (**IR 450–500°F**), light oil. **Single layer, don't crowd** — pat surfaces dry going in. Hard sear.
- 7 **Chop-and-sear:** add fresh sliced white onion alongside if you like; chop with two spatulas, let it sit **30–60 sec**, toss for crispy edges.
- 8 **Finish:** pull at **medium, 130–140°F**. Fresh lime + cilantro. Serve with salsas / chiles — that's where the heat comes from. Double-stacked tortillas, onion, cilantro, lime, flaky salt.

TROUBLESHOOTING

PROBLEM	CAUSE	FIX
Tough / chewy	Cut with the grain, or overcooked	Dice across the grain; pull at 130–140°F
No char	Griddle too cool or crowded	Single layer; recover to 450–500°F
Mealy / mushy	Over-thawed — sat fully thawed in the lime	Cook from barely-thawed, still cold
Gray, not seared	Wet surface or crowded pan	Pat dry going in; smaller batches; hotter pan
Bland	Under-salted	Salt to 1.3% by weight; finish with lime + flaky salt